

Recap — Local Summariser Manual

recap / recaplong / recapall / recapc / recapmail · MacBook Air M1, 8 GB · Ollama + Gemma 4 · functions in ~/.zshrc
· version 3.1, 4 Oct 2026

1. What is set up

Item	Name / location	Purpose
Functions	~/.zshrc — recap, recaplong, recapall, recapc, recapmail	Read the clipboard, summarise offline, save Markdown
Summaries folder	~/Summaries/YYYY-MM-DD-title.md	Every run saves a Markdown file here automatically
gemma4-sum (default)	~/Modelfile.g4 — FROM gemma4:e2b, num_ctx 12288, temperature 0.2	Current summary model. Runs 100% on GPU
gemma-sum	~/Modelfile.sum — FROM gemma3:4b, num_ctx 12288, temperature 0.2	Older Gemma 3 model. Useful as a second opinion
gemma-12k	gemma3:4b, num_ctx 12288, temperature 1	Writing, chat, brainstorming
llama3.2:3b	Base model	Used by recapmail

Nothing updates itself. `ollama pull gemma4:e2b` refreshes the base model; afterwards rebuild with `ollama create` (section 5).

2. Daily use

Copy the text (Cmd+C), open Terminal, type the command. The first run after a break is slower because the model has to load. Each summary prints on screen and is saved as Markdown in ~/Summaries, with the article's headline as the first line.

Command	What it does
recap	Adaptive summary: heading, gist, main points, and "Worth noting" only if there is more
recap short	One sentence plus up to 3 takeaways
recaplong	Long articles and transcripts. Reads the text in parts, then combines. Slow but far more accurate
recap changes	For circulars and rule changes. Names which clauses are new and which are existing, who must act, and from when
recap "focus on costs"	Your own focus. Also useful: recap "this is an explainer, not an editorial"
recapc	Same as recap, and also copies the summary to the clipboard
recapall	Several articles in one go (section 3)
recapmail	3-line email summary: sender, tasks, deadlines, reply needed
RECAP_MODEL=gemma-sum recap	Use a different model for this one run only
recap help	Lists the options

The first line, "Reading N words...", confirms what was captured. If the count looks wrong, copy again. To summarise a file instead of copying: `pbcopy < ~/file.txt` then recap.

3. Several articles in one go (recapall)

In a Word file, paste the first article, then on a line of its own type four @ signs (@@@@), then the next article, and so on. Use that marker, not --- or ###, because Word turns those into a horizontal line. Press Cmd+A, Cmd+C, then run `recapall`. Each article is summarised separately, so the length limit applies per article, not to the whole batch. Allow 30 to 90 seconds per article and keep the Mac awake and plugged in. Start each article with its headline, because the first line becomes the heading. At the end every summary is on the clipboard and in one saved Markdown file.

4. Length — the real limits

The context window (num_ctx 12288) holds roughly 7,000 words, but **accuracy falls long before that ceiling**. The model keeps producing confident output as quality degrades, so length is the single biggest risk to trust.

Article length	What to expect	What to run
Up to ~1,500 words	Reliable. Figures, names and attribution generally correct	recap
1,500 – 4,500 words	Mostly good (a 4,400-word essay checked clean); occasional dropped detail	recap, spot-check key figures

Article length	What to expect	What to run
Above ~5,000 words	Meaning can reverse in a single pass	recaplong

One real failure found in testing. In a 5,900-word essay, “without solitude there would be no America” became “independent thinking without solitude” — the argument reversed. The text fitted inside the context window, so length alone was the likely cause. This came from a single run, so treat the thresholds above as guidance, not a measured limit.

How recaplong works: it splits the text into roughly 1,200-word parts, takes detailed notes on each part separately, then writes the summary from the notes. On a 6,600-word transcript it kept every claim I checked accurate, but its “Worth noting” list repeated points, so expect to trim. Expect about 45 seconds per part, so a 6,000-word essay takes four to five minutes. The intermediate notes are saved next to the summary as a .txt file, useful when a claim needs checking. Change the part size with `RECAP_CHUNK=900 recaplong`.

5. Model, temperature and context

```
open -e ~/Modelfile.g4          # edit temperature or num_ctx, then save
ollama create gemma4-sum -f ~/Modelfile.g4 # rebuild, seconds, no new download
ollama show gemma4-sum          # check the settings took effect
ollama stop gemma4-sum          # unload the old copy
```

Task	Temperature
Summaries, facts, circulars, coding	0.1 – 0.3 (current: 0.2)
General questions	0.5 – 0.7
Drafting, ideas, creative writing	0.8 – 1.0

Building from scratch:

```
ollama pull gemma4:e2b
printf 'FROM gemma4:e2b\nPARAMETER num_ctx 12288\nPARAMETER temperature 0.2\n' > ~/Modelfile.g4
ollama create gemma4-sum -f ~/Modelfile.g4
```

Context length: gemma4:e2b supports 128K tokens, but num_ctx is capped at 12288 because the memory it needs has to fit in 8 GB. Raising it is possible — try 16384 and watch `ollama ps` — but it does not fix the accuracy fall described in section 4, so recaplong remains the better answer for long text. **Check memory** while a summary runs by opening a second Terminal window and typing `ollama ps`. The PROCESSOR column should read 100% GPU; a CPU/GPU split means the model no longer fits and will be slow.

Thinking mode: Gemma 4 and Qwen print their reasoning before the answer. The functions suppress this with `--think=false`, added automatically for models whose name starts with gemma4 or qwen. Gemma 3 does not accept the flag, which is why the rule is conditional.

6. Changing or re-installing a function

```
open -e ~/.zshrc          # opens in TextEdit
# replace the WHOLE recap() { ... } block, first line to closing brace, then Cmd+S
source ~/.zshrc           # load the change into this Terminal window
grep -c "^recap()" ~/.zshrc # must print 1 (2 means an old copy is still there)
```

Keep alias `recap='recap | tee >(pbcopy)'` exactly as written — no space between `>` and `(pbcopy)`. If TextEdit shows rich text, use Format > Make Plain Text first. The functions already strip stray “Here’s a summary...” openings and trailing “Related:” link lists, convert bullets to Markdown, and bold the “Worth noting” heading.

7. Troubleshooting

Problem	Cause and fix
“Only 3 words on the clipboard”	Clipboard did not hold the text. Copy again, or <code>pbcopy < ~/file.txt</code>
command not found: recap	Run <code>source ~/.zshrc</code> , or open a new Terminal window
Old behaviour after an edit	Forgot <code>source ~/.zshrc</code> , or two copies of the function exist (grep check above)
“Thinking...” block appears	<code>--think=false</code> missing, or the model name does not start with gemma4/qwen
Heading is wrong or blank	The first line of the copied text is not the headline — copy from the headline down
Summary reverses or garbles a long text	Text too long for one pass. Use <code>recaplong</code>
zsh: unknown file attribute: b	A space was typed in <code>> (pbcopy)</code> ; it must be <code>>(pbcopy)</code>
Mac slow, fan loud	<code>ollama ps</code> , then <code>ollama stop MODELNAME</code> ; quit heavy apps

8. What this model gets wrong — check these

Tested across circulars, editorials, newsletters, match reports, explainers, long essays and story collections. No invented facts were found in the summaries checked, but five faults repeat. Treat a summary as a map of the article, never as the final word.

Weakness	What to do
Dropped hedges. “Very difficult”, “possibly”, “the best explanation is” get trimmed, which makes claims sound firmer than they are	Re-read the source sentence before quoting a strong claim
Who said what. A lesson the author drew is credited to the person quoted. Charlie Munger has been given Morgan House’s line in every run	Verify every “according to X” before repeating it
New versus unchanged rules. In circulars, existing clauses can be listed as if they were changes	Use recap changes, then read the clauses it names yourself
Flattened names. “A journalist”, “a report” in place of the named person or publication	Go back to the article for names you need
Figures. A number from one scenario can migrate to another	Check any figure you will act on

Strongest on: news and match reports, explainers, research write-ups, market and business pieces. **Weakest on:** collections of quotes or anecdotes, where attribution slips most, and regulatory texts, where new and unchanged clauses blur. For an important document, run it a second time with RECAP_MODEL=gemma - sum recap and compare — where two different models agree, the summary is usually sound.